DIGITALAIKART

PREMIUM STUDY EDITION · NOVEMBER 2026

ICSE 2027

The 90-Day Board Plan

A date-locked plan for the 2027 CISCE timetable — from today to your last paper, built around the gaps that decide your marks.

OFFICIAL TIMETABLE INSIDE

ICSE Class X · Examinations 15 February – 31 March 2027

READ THIS PAGE FIRST

On 10 November 2026 the Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations published the ICSE and ISC timetable for 2027. The date your preparation stops being a feeling and becomes a schedule is the day that PDF went up.

This book is not a question bank and not a set of notes. You already have those, and so does everyone else in your class. What almost nobody has is a plan that fits the actual 2027 timetable — which papers fall on which dates, how many days sit between them, and what those in-between days are for. That is what this book gives you.

Two numbers explain why the plan matters more than another round of notes. The first is 93. That is how many days separate 14 November 2026 from your first paper on 15 February 2027. The second is 21. That is how many days inside your exam window you will not be writing a paper. Ninety-three days of preparation and twenty-one days of gap — both are large enough to lose the year, and large enough to win it.

1. Read Part 1 today. It is short and it changes how you read every paper you attempt afterwards.
2. Read Part 2 and mark up your own Gap Map with your actual subject combination. Ten minutes.
3. Start Part 3 on Monday 16 November 2026, or on the day you buy this — whichever is later. Do not wait for a clean Monday.
4. Keep Part 4 open on the day before each paper. It tells you what to do in the window you actually have, not in some ideal week.
5. Print the trackers in Part 5. A plan you cannot see on the wall does not survive.

ONE RULE BEFORE YOU START

Never change your study plan based on a date you read in a coaching video, a WhatsApp forward or this book. The timetable, the specimen papers and the regulations all live on cisce.org. This book tells you what those documents said on 14 November 2026 and how to build a plan on them; the document always wins. If CISCE issues a revision, re-draw the Gap Map in Part 2 and carry on.

THE SIX THINGS THAT ARE TRUE THIS YEAR

The six things that are true this year

Every ICSE year has its own shape. These are the six facts that make 2027 different from 2026, and each one changes what you should do between now and February.

Fact	What the official record says	What it means for you
The timetable is out	Released 10 November 2026. ICSE runs 15 February to 31 March 2027 across 2,835 centres in India and overseas.	Your revision no longer has a deadline. It has ten deadlines.
The cohort is large	2,69,955 ICSE candidates from 3,106 schools. Together with ISC, 3,79,980 candidates across 76 ICSE subjects and 60 ISC subjects.	You are not competing for a pass. You are competing for a grade band, and grade bands are decided by single marks.
The timings moved	Reading time now begins at 10:00 am and writing at 10:15 am. Until 2026 it was 10:45 am and 11:00 am. Candidates must be seated by 9:45 am.	Your body clock, your travel and your morning routine all shift 45 minutes earlier. Start practising at 10:15 am now.
Half the paper is now application	CISCE has set competency-based questions at roughly 50% for 2027, up from 40% in 2026 and 25% in 2025.	Rote answers that scored in 2024 score less now. The single biggest skill upgrade available to you is learning to answer unseen situations.
The specimen papers changed	New 2027 specimen papers with answer keys were published for 11 ICSE Class 10 subjects: English Language, Literature in English, History and Civics, Geography, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Robotics and Artificial Intelligence, Assistant Beauty Therapist and Assistant Hair Stylist.	For those subjects, the specimen is the closest thing to the real paper you will ever see. For every other subject, the 2026 structure still applies.
Questions are now skill-tagged	Most questions in the 2027 specimen papers carry a skill tag in the margin — Recall, Understanding, Application, Analysis, Evaluation, Creativity.	You can now see, question by question, where the easy marks are and where the paper expects you to think. Almost nobody reads those tags. Read them.

THE ONE-LINE VERSION

The 2027 paper rewards a student who can apply a concept to a situation they have never seen. The 2023 paper rewarded a student who could reproduce a paragraph. If your revision is still mostly re-reading, you are preparing for a paper that no longer exists.

WHAT'S INSIDE

What's inside

01 **Know the exam** — 5
The 2027 paper, decoded from the official documents — what it rewards, what it punishes, and where your marks actually sit.

02 **The gap map** — 10
Ten exam dates, thirty-one days, twenty-one free days in between. This is the part of the year almost everyone mismanages.

03 **The 90-day plan** — 15
Ninety-three days, three phases, one rule. What to do in each week between today and 15 February 2027.

04 **Subject playbooks** — 23
For each paper: the date, the window you actually get, the highest-yield moves, and the last forty-eight hours.

05 **Tools, trackers and the last mile** — 35
Answer writing, the error ledger, mocks, internal marks, memory, parents, and the checklists you print.

01

Know the exam

The 2027 paper, decoded from the official documents — what it rewards, what it punishes, and where your marks actually sit.

WHERE YOUR HUNDRED MARKS ACTUALLY LIVE

Where your hundred marks actually live

Almost every ICSE student carries a vague picture of “100 marks” and studies as if all hundred were sitting in the answer booklet. They are not. Before you plan a single hour, know which marks are already banked, which are still winnable, and which are gone.

Group I and Group II: the 80 + 20 split

English, your second language, History Civics and Geography, Mathematics, Science, Economics, Commercial Studies, a modern or classical foreign language, and Environmental Science are all marked 80 for the board paper and 20 for internal assessment. That 20 is the school's assessment — projects, coursework, practicals — submitted online to CISCE by your school.

Group III: the 50 + 50 split

Computer Applications, Economic Applications, Commercial Applications, Art, Performing Arts, Home Science, Cookery, Fashion Designing, Physical Education, Yoga, Technical Drawing Applications, Environmental Application, Mass Media and Communication, Hospitality Management, and the Section B vocational subjects are marked 50 for the board paper and 50 for internal assessment.

THE STRATEGIC CONSEQUENCE NOBODY EXPLAINS

In a Group III subject, half your marks are already decided before you enter the hall. A student who has been careless with a Computer Applications file is not fighting for 100 — they are fighting for 60. Go and look at your internal marks this week. Not in February. The number you find changes how much time that subject deserves.

The honest arithmetic

Take a typical ICSE student offering ten subjects: English Language, Literature in English, Mathematics, History and Civics, Geography, Hindi, Physics, Chemistry, Biology and Computer Applications. Total marks across ten subjects: 1,000.

Subject type	Board marks	Internal marks	Share of total
Nine subjects at 80 + 20 (Group I, Group II, English Language and Literature)	720	180	90%
One Group III subject at 50 + 50 (Computer Applications)	50	50	10%
Total	770	230	1,000

Illustrative split for a ten-subject combination. Exact internal components vary by subject — confirm yours with your school.

Read that table again. Somewhere between a fifth and a third of your final percentage is already written down in a school register. You cannot improve it by studying harder in January. You can only confirm it is correct, and then aim everything else at the marks that are still in play.

What the pass rules actually say

The regulations are specific and they are not what most students assume:

- You must be entered for a minimum of six subjects: the three Group I subjects, two from Group II, and one or two from Group III.
- The pass mark for each subject is 33%.
- To receive the Pass Certificate and Statement of Marks you must pass at least five subjects, and English must be one of them.
- You must also hold a pass grade in Socially Useful Productive Work and Community Service, assessed internally by your school.
- Results are reported as grades 1 to 9, where 1 is the highest. Grades 1 and 2 read as “Very good”, 3 to 5 as a pass with credit, 6 and 7 as a pass, and 8 and 9 as a failure.

> **THE ENGLISH RULE**
>
> English is the one subject you cannot fail and still pass the ICSE. It is also, by timetable, the very first paper you sit — 15 February, 10:15 am. No other subject carries that combination of consequence and position. If you do one thing differently after reading this book, make it this: do not let English Language be the paper you prepare last.

Why grades 1 and 2 are a different project

A pass needs 33. A grade 1 needs a very high aggregate, and the students who get there are rarely the ones who studied the most hours. They are the ones who lost the fewest marks to things that were not knowledge: a formula written without its unit, a diagram without labels, a letter without a format, a summary over the word limit, a question left blank because it looked unfamiliar.

Part 4 of this book is largely about those marks, because they are the cheapest ones available to you and they are the ones that coaching centres never bill for.

THE TIMING CHANGE, AND THE FIFTEEN MINUTES

The timing change, and the fifteen minutes

This is the most operationally important change in 2027 and it is the one most students will waste, because it sounds administrative rather than academic.

	Until 2026	From 2027
Candidates seated	10:30 am	9:45 am
Reading time begins	10:45 am	10:00 am
Writing begins	11:00 am	10:15 am

The paper has not got shorter. Your morning has got earlier, and your reading window is now the only fifteen minutes in the exam where you are not marked on speed. Used badly it is fifteen minutes of nervous page-turning; used well it is worth more than a week of revision.

The fifteen-minute protocol

Do this in the same order every time, in every mock, until it is automatic:

1. **Minutes 0–2: count the paper.** Check the number of printed pages against the page numbers on the paper. Check that every question you expect is there. If a page is missing or a print is unclear, raise your

hand now, not in minute 90.

2. **Minutes 2–5: read the instructions block.** How many questions are compulsory? How many choices? Is there a word limit? Is there a separate answer booklet for a section? Students lose whole questions to instructions they never read.
3. **Minutes 5–9: read every question in full, including the ones you plan to skip.** Not to solve them — to let your brain start on them. You cannot un-read a question.
4. **Minutes 9–12: mark the paper.** Put a dot against the questions you can do cold, a question mark against the ones you can attempt with effort, and a cross against the ones that are unfamiliar. This is your route through the paper.
5. **Minutes 12–15: write your time budget on the top of the answer booklet.** One line per question — the clock time by which you will leave it. Then keep that promise.

THE MISTAKE THAT COSTS THE MOST

Do not start writing during reading time. Invigilators do cancel papers. And do not spend the fifteen minutes drafting your first answer in your head — that is the one question you are most confident about and the one that least needs the rehearsal.

What the earlier start does to your body

Writing at 10:15 am instead of 11:00 am means your brain must be at full speed 45 minutes sooner. If you have spent two years studying at night, that is a real disadvantage and it is cheap to fix. From January, move your hardest subject to 9:30–11:30 am. From February, sit every mock at exactly 10:15 am with a clock on the desk. By 15 February, 10:15 will feel like the middle of your day.

ALSO WORTH CHECKING ON YOUR ADMIT CARD

Reporting time, centre address and the duration printed for each paper. Durations vary across ICSE subjects — the English papers and the Science papers run two hours, several language and other papers run three — so read the duration off the official timetable for your own subjects rather than assuming. Plan your practice papers at the real length from day one.

HALF THE PAPER IS NOW A THINKING TEST

Half the paper is now a thinking test

CISCE has been moving this for three years and 2027 is the biggest single jump: roughly 25% competency-based questions in 2025, 40% in 2026, and about 50% in 2027. Competency here means the question asks you to apply, analyse, evaluate or create — not to reproduce.

The board has been unusually transparent about what this looks like. In the 2027 specimen papers, questions carry a skill tag in the margin: Recall, Understanding, Application, Analysis, Evaluation, Creativity. Open the English Language specimen and you will see the composition options tagged Creativity and Evaluation, the letter tagged Recall and Analysis, the notice and email tagged Recall and Application, and the comprehension questions tagged Understanding and Analysis in sequence.

HOW TO USE THE TAGS

Do not read the specimen as a sample paper. Read it as a marking philosophy. For each question, note the tag, then ask: what would a full-mark answer do that a memorised answer would not? Write that one line in the margin of your own copy. Twenty minutes with one specimen paper teaches you more about the 2027 examiner than two hours of notes.

Three habits that used to work and now cost marks

Old habit	Why it fails in 2027	Replace it with
Reproducing a memorised definition word for word, then stopping.	A recall question is now worth one or two marks. The four-mark part that follows asks you to use the definition in a situation.	Write the definition in one line, then immediately write one example or one consequence. Two sentences, not one.
Learning answers to the questions in the back of the textbook.	The paper is allowed to set questions from any part of the syllabus. The specimen fixes the format, not the content.	Learn to answer the question in front of you: underline the command word, identify what it asks you to do, answer that.
Finishing early and stopping.	Application questions reward a second pass. Half the paper now needs you to check whether your answer actually addressed the situation given.	Reserve the last ten minutes to re-read each answer against its question, and to add the unit, the label, the example you skipped.

The command words that decide your mark

ICSE questions are not vague, but they are read vaguely. The verb at the start of the question tells you the shape of the answer expected, and students routinely write the wrong shape and lose marks for content they actually knew.

Command word	What the examiner expects	Typical failure
State / Name / Define	One precise line. No explanation.	A paragraph that buries the answer in the third sentence.
Explain	A reason, with a because or a therefore. Cause, not restatement.	Rewording the question as the answer.
Describe	A sequence of features or steps, in order.	A definition instead of a description.
Give reasons	Two or more distinct reasons, each on its own line.	One reason written twice in different words.
Compare / Distinguish	Both things named, and a basis of comparison for each point.	Describing one thing only.
Suggest / Why do you think	Your judgement plus the evidence for it. There is no single right answer, but there is a weak answer.	Silence, because the student thinks there is no answer in the book.

The last row is where the 50% competency shift shows up most plainly. “Suggest” and “why do you think” questions now appear in subjects that never used to ask them. They are marked on the quality of reasoning, not on matching a key. A student who writes two sentences of real reasoning beats a student who writes nothing because the answer was not in the book.

02

The gap map

Ten exam dates, thirty-one days, twenty-one free days in between. This is the part of the year almost everyone mismanages.

YOUR TIMETABLE, AS PUBLISHED

Your timetable, as published

This is the ICSE 2027 schedule as released by CISCE on 10 November 2026. All papers begin at 10:15 am except the Art papers, which begin at 09:00 am. Candidates must be seated by 9:45 am.

Date	Day	Paper
15 Feb	Mon	English Language — English Paper 1
16 Feb	Tue	Art Paper 4 (Applied Art)
18 Feb	Thu	Literature in English — English Paper 2
22 Feb	Mon	Mathematics
23 Feb	Tue	Art Paper 1 (Still Life)
24 Feb	Wed	Group III Elective, Section B (Robotics and AI, vocational papers)
26 Feb	Fri	History and Civics — H.C.G. Paper 1
1 Mar	Mon	Geography — H.C.G. Paper 2
2 Mar	Tue	Art Paper 2 (Nature Drawing / Painting)
4 Mar	Thu	Hindi
8 Mar	Mon	Physics — Science Paper 1
12 Mar	Fri	Chemistry — Science Paper 2
15 Mar	Mon	Biology — Science Paper 3
16 Mar	Tue	Art Paper 3 (Original Composition)
17 Mar	Wed	Group III Elective, Section A (Computer Applications, Commercial Applications, Economic Applications, Physical Education, Home Science, Music, Dance, Drama, Fashion Designing and others)
19 Mar	Fri	Group I Languages (Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, Sanskrit, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu and others)
25 Mar	Thu	Environmental Science (Group II Elective)
29 Mar	Mon	Commercial Studies (Group II Elective)
31 Mar	Wed	Economics, French, Sanskrit (Group II Elective)

Source: CISCE ICSE Year 2027 examination timetable, published 10 November 2026. Confirm the version for your own subjects at cisce.org before you plan around it.

THE GAP MAP

The gap map

Here is the same timetable arranged the way a student actually experiences it: not as dates, but as windows. For each paper, how many clear days you get before it, and how many you get after it before the next one.

This table is drawn for a common ten-subject combination — English Language, Literature in English, Mathematics, History and Civics, Geography, Hindi, Physics, Chemistry, Biology and Computer Applications. Your own combination will differ; the shape will not.

Paper	Date	Days since last paper	Free days before it
English Language	15 Feb	—	—
Literature in English	18 Feb	3	2 (16–17 Feb)
Mathematics	22 Feb	4	3 (19–21 Feb)
History and Civics	26 Feb	4	3 (23–25 Feb)
Geography	1 Mar	3	2 (27–28 Feb)
Hindi	4 Mar	3	2 (2–3 Mar)
Physics	8 Mar	4	3 (5–7 Mar)
Chemistry	12 Mar	4	3 (9–11 Mar)
Biology	15 Mar	3	2 (13–14 Mar)
Computer Applications	17 Mar	2	1 (16 Mar)

31
DAYS FROM FIRST TO LAST PAPER

10
PAPERS WRITTEN

21
DAYS WITH NO EXAM

93
DAYS FROM TODAY TO PAPER ONE

READ THE THIRD COLUMN AGAIN

Twenty-one of your thirty-one exam-window days have no paper in them. That is not a holiday. That is where the difference between a 78% and an 88% is decided, because it is the only stretch of the year when you are revising for a known paper on a known date with nothing else competing for the hours.

THREE TRAPS IN THIS TIMETABLE

Three traps in this timetable

The 2027 ICSE timetable is not unusually cruel. It is unusually generous with gaps, and generosity is its own trap. Three specific failure modes follow directly from these dates.

Trap one: the first-paper cliff

English Language falls on the first day. It is the paper with the highest marks-per-hour of anything you will write, it is compulsory to pass, and it arrives before you have had a single board exam to calibrate your speed. Students spend November and December on Physics because Physics feels hard, and reach 14 February having written exactly one timed English paper in their life.

The fix is unglamorous: one full English Language paper, timed, at 10:15 am, in the first week of January, and one every fortnight after that. Five papers between January and February is enough to remove the surprise.

Trap two: the dead day

You finish Mathematics on 22 February. History and Civics is on the 26th. There are three clear days. Almost every student spends all three on History and Civics — and then arrives at Geography on 1 March having not opened Geography since the previous weekend.

This is the dead-day pattern, and it compounds. By the time you reach Physics on 8 March, your Biology has been untouched for weeks. The timetable lets you do this. It will not stop you.

Trap three: the long tail

Your last paper is on 31 March if you offer Economics, French or Sanskrit; 29 March if you offer Commercial Studies; 19 March if your final paper is a Group I language. Whatever your case, there is a stretch at the end where the papers are spaced widely and your motivation is lowest — you have already sat six or seven papers, and the finish line feels far. Students lose their last two subjects here, and those two subjects count exactly as much as the first two.

> **THE RULE THAT FIXES ALL THREE**
>
> Never let more than 48 hours pass without opening a subject you have not yet been examined in. That single sentence, applied for five months, is worth more than any timetable app. Everything in Part 3 is built to make it possible.

THE 3-3-3 BLOCK

The 3-3-3 block

Here is the operating rule for every gap in the exam window. It is deliberately simple, because complicated systems collapse in February.

On any clear day between two papers, divide your study hours into three blocks of unequal purpose, in this order:

Block	Share of the day	What it is for	What it is not for
Block A — Next paper	About 60%	The paper you sit next. Past questions, weak topics, timed sections.	Re-reading the whole textbook again.
Block B — The paper after	About 25%	One pass over the subject two papers ahead. Definitions, diagrams, formulae, the error ledger.	Deep new learning. There is no time and it will not stick.
Block C — Maintenance	About 15%	One 20-minute recall drill on a subject further out. Blank-page test, not reading.	Anything that needs a pen and a full hour.

Worked example, using the real dates. You sit Mathematics on Monday 22 February. History and Civics is Friday 26 February, Geography Monday 1 March. On Tuesday 23, Wednesday 24 and Thursday 25 you have three clear days.

- **Tuesday 23:** Block A on History and Civics (about 4 hours), Block B on Geography (about 1.5 hours), Block C on Physics definitions (20 minutes).
- **Wednesday 24:** Block A on History and Civics (about 4 hours), Block B on Geography (about 1.5 hours), Block C on Biology diagrams (20 minutes).

- **Thursday 25:** Block A on History and Civics (about 3 hours), one timed History section (about 1 hour), Block C on Chemistry equations (20 minutes).

Notice what has happened. Geography has had three passes before its own gap begins. Physics, Biology and Chemistry each got a short, cheap touch that keeps them alive. And History and Civics still got the majority of the hours, which is what the next paper deserves.

WHY 60 / 25 / 15 AND NOT 80 / 20 / 0

Because a subject you have not opened in three weeks does not come back in the two days before its paper. It comes back in about five. The 25% block is not generosity — it is the cheapest insurance in the whole plan, and it costs you less than an hour a day.

If you only have one clear day

Some combinations give you a single free day between papers — 16 March, before Computer Applications, is one. On a one-day gap, drop Block B entirely. Spend the morning on the next paper, the afternoon on the paper after it, and twenty minutes at night on recall. Do not attempt three subjects deeply in one day; you will do none of them well.

03

The 90-day plan

Ninety-three days, three phases, one rule. What to do in each week between today and 15 February 2027.

THE SHAPE OF THE CAMPAIGN

The shape of the campaign

You have 93 days until your first paper. Those days are not one long stretch of revision, and treating them as one is why so many students arrive in February having “revised” everything twice and mastered nothing. The 93 days split into three phases with different jobs.

Phase	Dates	Days	The job	The mistake
Phase 1 — Close the syllabus	16 Nov – 31 Dec 2026	46	Finish every chapter you have not finished. Get one full pass over everything.	Revising chapters you already like, for the third time, while two chapters sit untouched.
Phase 2 — Convert to marks	1 Jan – 31 Jan 2027	31	Full papers, timed sections, the error ledger. Turn knowledge into marks.	Still learning new content, so no paper is ever attempted under time.
Phase 3 — Taper	1 Feb – 14 Feb 2027	14	Your own notes only. Recall drills, diagrams, formulae, sleep.	Starting a new reference book, or a new tuition, in the last fortnight.
Exam phase — Operate	15 Feb – 31 Mar 2027	45	The 3-3-3 block, one paper at a time, no post-mortems.	Studying the paper you have already written, or the one four weeks away.

The two-track rule

At every point in these 93 days you are doing two things at once, and the ratio between them changes:

- **Track A — new ground.** Chapters you have not yet finished. In Phase 1 this is most of your time. By Phase 3 it is zero.
- **Track B — spaced revision.** Chapters you have already finished, revisited on a schedule rather than when you feel like it. In Phase 1 this is a small daily block. By Phase 3 it is everything.

Phase	Track A (new)	Track B (revision)
Phase 1	70%	30%
Phase 2	20%	80%
Phase 3	0%	100%

The single most common failure in the 93 days is staying in Phase 1 too long. Students who are still “finishing the syllabus” in the third week of January have no time to convert knowledge into marks, and conversion is where most of the improvement actually lives.

SET A HARD DATE, NOT A TARGET

Write this on the first page of your notebook: 31 December 2026, syllabus closed. Whatever is unfinished on that date gets finished in the first week of January and no later. A date you cannot move forces choices; a target you can move does not.

PHASE 1: CLOSE THE SYLLABUS

Phase 1: close the syllabus

46 days, 16 November to 31 December 2026. The output of this phase is not understanding. It is coverage: every chapter touched, every chapter marked as done, and a one-page summary written by you for each one.

Before week one, do this on a single sheet: list every subject, and under it every chapter or unit in the syllabus. Mark each one Done, Partly or Not started. That sheet is your Phase 1 map, and it will tell you something uncomfortable — usually that two subjects are almost entirely untouched.

The weekly targets

Week	Dates	Closing target for the week	Sunday checkpoint
1	16–22 Nov	Finish the two most-behind chapters across your weakest two subjects. Not the easiest ones — the most-behind ones.	Can you write the key definitions of both chapters on a blank page, no notes?
2	23–29 Nov	Two more chapters closed, plus one page of your own summary for every chapter closed so far.	Are your summaries actually one page, or three? Rewrite the worst one.
3	30 Nov–6 Dec	The science practical syllabus and diagrams. Label every diagram in Physics, Chemistry and Biology from memory.	Draw three diagrams cold, label them, then check against the textbook.
4	7–13 Dec	The writing subjects: composition and letter formats for English Language, and the format conventions of your second language.	Write one composition in 30 minutes and one letter in 20, timed.
5	14–20 Dec	Every remaining Not-started chapter. This is the week that decides whether 31 December is real.	Count your Not-started list. It should be zero or close to it.
6	21–27 Dec	First full revision pass of the two subjects you finished earliest — they are the ones you have already begun to forget.	Blank-page test on the first three chapters of each. Score yourself honestly.
7	28–31 Dec	Close the last gaps. Build your error ledger (Part 5). Write your 31 December summary.	Syllabus closed? Yes or no. If no, name the exact chapters and give them the first week of January.

ON THE WINTER BREAK

Many ICSE schools break in the last week of December. If yours does, that week is worth roughly three normal weeks and it is the best opportunity in the whole calendar. Do not spend it on a holiday. If your school does not break, ignore this box and use weeks 5 and 6 as written — the plan assumes normal school days everywhere else.

PHASE 2: CONVERT TO MARKS

Phase 2: convert to marks

31 days, 1 January to 31 January 2027. The job changes completely. You are no longer learning; you are learning to score. This is the phase most students skip, and it is the phase that produces the largest single jump in marks.

The three instruments

1. **Full papers under time.** One paper per subject per week at minimum, at 10:15 am, with no phone, no notes and the real duration. Use the 2027 specimen paper first, then past board papers.
2. **Timed sections.** When you do not have two or three hours, take one section — the comprehension, the numericals, the map work — and time only that. Fifteen focused minutes beats an hour of re-reading.
3. **The error ledger.** One notebook, one page per subject. Every mark you lose gets an entry. Part 5 explains exactly how to keep it. Students who keep one properly gain more than students who add a second tuition.

The weekly pattern

Week	Dates	Focus	Output by Sunday
1	1–3 Jan	First timed English Language paper. Set the baseline you will beat in February.	One full English paper marked against the official answer key.
2	4–10 Jan	One full paper in each of your three highest-mark subjects.	Three marked papers, three ledger pages started.
3	11–17 Jan	One full paper in every remaining subject. This is a diagnostic week, not a performance week.	A ranked list of your subjects by percentage lost.
4	18–24 Jan	Attack the bottom two subjects on that ranked list. Nothing else gets priority.	Two subjects moved up the list.
5	25–31 Jan	Second round of full papers in your weakest four. Compare against week 3, not against your friends.	A written note of what actually improved and what did not.

THE ONE THING TO STOP DOING IN JANUARY

Do not mark your own paper generously. ICSE marking is point-based and examiners do not award marks for effort or for a correct final answer with no working. If you cannot find the mark in the official answer key, you did not earn it. Generous self-marking in January produces a shock in February.

Reading your score honestly

A paper score on its own tells you almost nothing. A paper broken into four causes tells you exactly what to do next week:

Cause of lost marks	How to recognise it	The fix
Did not know it	The answer is genuinely absent from your memory.	Back to Phase 1 for that chapter. This is the only cause that needs new learning.
Knew it, forgot it	You recognised the answer in the key and were annoyed.	Spaced revision. Put it on a 1-3-7 schedule (Part 5). Not more reading.
Knew it, misread the question	Your answer was right for a different question.	Command-word drill. Ten questions a day, just identifying what is being asked.
Knew it, ran out of time	Blank space at the end of the booklet.	Time budgeting in the reading window, and practising at real speed, not at comfortable speed.

Almost every student believes their problem is the first cause. After one honest paper, most discover that two-thirds of their lost marks come from the last three — which is the best news in this book, because those

three are fixable in weeks, not months.

PHASE 3: THE TAPER

Phase 3: the taper

14 days, 1 to 14 February 2027. The temptation in this fortnight is to do more: a new reference book, a crash course, a fresh set of notes from a friend. Every one of those makes the outcome worse. This phase is about consolidating what you have and arriving at 15 February rested and fast.

The fourteen days

Dates	What happens
1–4 Feb	One full paper a day in your first four papers: English Language, Literature, Mathematics, History and Civics. Mark each one the same evening.
5–7 Feb	No new content anywhere. Your own one-page summaries only. Rebuild your formula sheet and diagram list from memory, then correct them.
8–11 Feb	One full paper a day in Geography, Hindi, Physics and Chemistry. Keep Biology and Computer Applications on a 20-minute daily recall drill.
12–13 Feb	English Language only. Two compositions, two letters, one full comprehension, one grammar set. This is the paper that opens the season.
14 Feb	Nothing new. Pack your bag, check your centre, read your English Language summary, sleep by 10 pm.

WHY THE LAST FORTNIGHT IS NOT FOR LEARNING

New material learned in the final two weeks is the least retrievable material you will own on exam day, and it displaces the material you already had. The students who gain marks in February are the ones who spend it making what they know faster and more reliable, not larger.

The 15 February morning

You are seated by 9:45 am. Reading begins at 10:00. Writing begins at 10:15. That means you should be awake by 6:00, have eaten by 7:00, and be at the centre by 9:00 — not 9:30, because 2,835 centres means queues, and a queue is the only thing on this list that can actually ruin your paper.

Carry: admit card, a transparent pouch with two blue or black pens, a pencil, an eraser, a sharpener, a ruler, and a wristwatch. No phone in the hall, no smart watch, no paper of your own. Check your centre's specific instructions on the admit card — they vary by centre and they override habit.

THE WEEKLY TEMPLATE

The weekly template

A plan that does not fit an ordinary school week is a plan you will abandon by the second Monday. This is the template to copy into your notebook and adjust once.

School days (Monday to Friday)

Slot	Time	What goes here
Morning	6:15–6:50	Recall only. Twenty minutes on a subject you are not studying today, using the blank-page test. No reading.
After school	15:30–17:00	Track A: the new chapter. This is your hardest cognitive block, so it gets your hardest subject.
Break	17:00–17:45	Off. Actually off. Not “off with a phone”.
Evening	17:45–19:15	Track A continues, or a timed section if the chapter is closed.
Night	20:30–21:15	Track B: revision of a closed chapter, plus ledger entries from the day.
Before sleep	21:45	Five minutes: write tomorrow's three targets. Then stop.

Non-school days and holidays

Four longer blocks instead of five short ones, and the extra hours go to the subject that is furthest behind — not spread evenly, which is the mistake that keeps weak subjects weak.

Block	Time	What goes here
1	8:00–10:15	The most-behind subject. Deliberately first, while you are freshest.
2	10:45–12:45	A full timed paper or a long section.
3	16:00–18:00	Track A or B, depending on the phase.
4	19:30–20:45	Recall drills and the error ledger.

THE FOUR-HOUR CEILING

Nobody does six hours of real study in a day. They do six hours of sitting. Cap genuine study at about four hours on school days and six on holidays, and protect the sleep instead. A tired brain at 10:15 am on 15 February is a bigger risk than a chapter you did not finish.

THE EXAM-PHASE OPERATING SYSTEM

The exam-phase operating system

From 15 February the plan stops being a study plan and becomes a rhythm. Ten papers, thirty-one days, twenty-one free days. Here is the daily loop.

The 48-hour protocol, for every paper

When	What you do	What you must not do
T minus 2 days	Last full pass over the subject. One timed section. Update the error ledger with everything you still get wrong.	Start a chapter you have never read.
T minus 1 day	Your own one-page summary, your formula sheet, your diagram list, and the error ledger. Then stop by 6 pm.	Attempt a full paper. Sit a new topic. Stay up past 10:30.

When	What you do	What you must not do
Exam morning	Thirty minutes maximum: formulae, diagram labels, key definitions. Nothing else.	Discuss the syllabus with classmates outside the hall.
The paper	The fifteen-minute protocol, then your time budget, then the questions in your marked order.	Leave a question blank without writing something.
The evening after	Twenty minutes to write three lines in your ledger. Then Block A for the next paper — the same evening, not the next morning.	Analyse the paper with friends. Check answers. Look up what you wrote.

THE TWENTY-MINUTE RESET

The single most damaging habit in the exam window is the post-paper post-mortem. Comparing answers in the school corridor changes nothing about the paper you have written and reliably damages the paper you have not. Write three lines in your ledger, close the book, and start on the next subject before you leave the building.

The maintenance block, every single day

Twenty minutes. One subject. The blank-page test, not reading. Rotate through the subjects you have not yet been examined in, in the order they appear on the timetable. This is the block that makes the 3-3-3 rule possible, and it is the block everyone drops first when they are tired.

A blank-page test works like this: close every book, take one sheet, write everything you can remember about a named topic for eight minutes, then open the book and mark what you missed in red. The red list is what you revise next time. It takes twenty minutes, it needs no planning, and it is the highest-value twenty minutes in your day.

THE FIRST WEEK OF THE WINDOW IS THE HARDEST

You sit English Language on 15 February, Literature on the 18th and Mathematics on the 22nd — three papers in eight days, before the rhythm exists. Plan that week on paper now, in November, while you are calm. By the fourth paper the loop runs itself; the first three are the ones that need a written plan.

What a good exam-phase day looks like

Time	Activity
6:30–7:00	Maintenance block: blank-page test on a later subject.
7:00–9:00	Breakfast, travel, seated at the centre by 9:45. No last-minute cramming.
9:45–12:15	The paper.
12:15–13:30	Lunch, and a genuine break. Do not discuss the paper.
13:30–14:00	Twenty minutes: three ledger lines, then close it.
14:00–17:30	Block A: the next paper, with a timed section.
17:30–18:30	Off.
18:30–20:30	Block B: the paper after next.

Time	Activity
20:30–21:00	Light revision of the next paper's summary sheet.
21:30	Sleep. Not 11:30. Sleep.

04

Subject playbooks

For each paper: the date, the window you actually get, the highest-yield moves, and the last forty-eight hours.

HOW TO READ THESE PAGES

How to read these pages

Each playbook is written for the day you actually have, not for an ideal month. That means every one of them starts with the same two facts: when the paper falls, and what the timetable gives you before it.

Three things to note before you use them. First, where CISCE has published a 2027 specimen paper and answer key for a subject, that specimen is the most reliable guide you have to the shape of the paper — read it before anything else. Second, where it has not, the 2026 structure still applies. Third, the topic-wise weightage in the official Regulations and Syllabuses for 2027 is guaranteed; the specimen only fixes the format. So use the syllabus document for what to study and the specimen for how it will be asked.

A NOTE ON DURATIONS

Paper lengths differ across ICSE subjects, and the timetable prints the duration against each paper. Read it there for your own subjects and practise at that exact length. A student who practises a three-hour paper in two hours has practised a different paper.

ENGLISH LANGUAGE — MONDAY 15 FEBRUARY

English Language — Monday 15 February

Paper	English Paper 1
Marks	80 board + 20 internal
Duration	2 hours, plus 15 minutes reading from 10:00 am
Structure	Five compulsory questions. Internal choice only in Question 1 and Question 2.
Why it matters most	It is the first paper of the season, it is compulsory to pass, and it sets the tone for the nine papers after it.

This is the highest return-on-effort paper in the ICSE, and it is the one students prepare least, because it feels like something you either can or cannot do. You can. The paper is five fixed questions with fixed mark values, and every one of them is trainable.

The paper, question by question

Question	Task	Marks	Time
1	Composition, 300–350 words, from about five options	20	30 min
2	Letter — formal or friendly, from two options	10	20 min
3	Notice (5) and email (5) on the same situation	10	12 min
4	Unseen passage of about 500 words, with vocabulary, short answers and a summary	20	35 min
5	Functional grammar — prepositions, conjunctions, verbs, sentence structure	20	18 min

Question	Task	Marks	Time
	Review		5 min

THE MOST USEFUL SENTENCE IN THE SPECIMEN PAPER

The 2027 specimen tells you, in the paper itself, not to spend more than 30 minutes on Question 1 and not more than 20 minutes on Question 2. That is CISCE telling you where the marks are thin. Most students spend 45 minutes on the composition because it feels like the important one, and then write a rushed summary and a careless grammar section — losing more marks in the last 20 minutes than they gained in the extra 15.

Question 1: the composition

You will usually be offered a story opening, an account of a personal experience, an argument for or against a statement, a description of a task or project, and a picture prompt. The 2027 specimen tags these Creativity and Evaluation — which tells you what is being marked: originality and the quality of your thinking, not vocabulary.

Three decisions win this question:

1. **Choose in ninety seconds, then commit.** Pick the option you have an actual opinion about, not the one that sounds impressive. A plainly written account of something that happened to you outscores a stiff attempt at philosophy.
2. **Plan for three minutes, in the margin.** Five points, in order. Students who skip this produce a middle that wanders and a conclusion that repeats the introduction.
3. **Write a first line that does something.** A statement, a question, a small scene. Not “In this composition I am going to tell you about…”.

Length discipline matters. Three hundred to three hundred and fifty words is about a page and a half of handwriting. Too short reads as thin; too long reads as uncontrolled and costs you the time you needed for Question 4. Practise counting: know what 320 words looks like in your own handwriting.

The one habit to build in December

Write one composition a week, timed at 30 minutes, on a prompt you did not choose — pick at random from a list. Choosing freely every time trains a skill you will not have on 15 February, when the option you wanted may simply not be there.

Question 2: the letter

Two options, one formal and one friendly, ten marks, twenty minutes. Format is explicitly part of the assessment, which means the marks start before your first sentence: sender's address, date, receiver's address and salutation for a formal letter; a casual salutation and a sign-off that matches the relationship for a friendly one.

Formal letter	Friendly letter
Sender's address, date, receiver's address, subject line, salutation, body in two or three paragraphs, closing, signature.	Salutation that fits the relationship, three or four short paragraphs, warm closing, your name.

Formal letter	Friendly letter
Tone: polite, precise, no contractions, no exclamation marks.	Tone: natural and personal — but still organised, still punctuated.
The purpose is stated in the first two lines and the request in the last paragraph.	The purpose can be announced later, but the letter still needs a reason to exist.

THE TEN-MARK LEAK

Students lose three or four marks on this question for format alone: a missing date, a subject line where none is needed, a formal letter signed “Yours lovingly”. Learn two templates cold — one formal, one friendly — and never improvise the frame.

English Language, continued

Question 3: notice and email

Five marks each, twelve minutes, and the easiest ten marks on the paper. The notice is written for a notice board: a heading, the date, and the essential facts — what, when, where, who, and what the reader must do. Boxed, brief, no paragraphs. The email covers the same situation for a specific recipient: a subject line, an appropriate salutation, two short paragraphs, a closing.

The trap here is writing an essay in a box. A notice is not prose. If your notice runs to more than about sixty words, you have written the wrong document.

Question 4: the comprehension passage

About five hundred words, twenty marks, and it breaks into three distinct tasks that need three different approaches.

Part	What it asks	How to answer it
Vocabulary	Choose the correct meaning of a word as used in the passage, and give the opposite of another.	Read the sentence around the word, not the word alone. Two or three of the four options will be correct meanings in general and wrong in this passage.
Short answers	Answer briefly, in your own words.	One or two sentences. Use the passage's idea, not its phrasing — questions tagged Understanding and Analysis are testing whether you understood, not whether you can copy.
Summary	In not more than fifty words, explain a specified part of the passage.	Eight marks. This is the most under-practised item in the whole paper and the one where marks are most easily lost.

How to write a fifty-word summary that earns eight marks

The instruction tells you exactly what to summarise and the limit tells you the shape. A summary is not a shortened retelling. It is the main ideas with the detail removed.

1. Underline the part of the passage you have been asked to summarise. Do not summarise the whole passage if the question names a section.

2. Find the three or four main points and write each as a short phrase in the margin.
3. Join them into continuous prose in your own words — not a list, not the passage's sentences copied.
4. Count the words. Fifty is a hard limit and going over it is the most common way to lose marks here. A summary of 48 words that covers three points beats 70 words that covers four.
5. Do not add opinion, and do not add a conclusion. Neither is in the passage, so neither belongs in the summary.

PRACTISE THIS ONE ITEM FOUR TIMES BEFORE FEBRUARY

Write four summaries — one a fortnight from December — on four different passages, and count the words every time. Eight marks is a tenth of the paper, and it is decided by a discipline that takes twenty minutes to learn.

Question 5: grammar

Twenty marks of functional grammar: prepositions, conjunctions, verb forms and sentence structure. It is the least interesting question on the paper and the most reliable place to pick up marks, because it is finite. There is a fixed set of structures that ICSE tests, and they repeat.

The method: twenty minutes a day for six weeks, one topic at a time, and every wrong answer goes into your error ledger with the rule beside it. Not a grammar book cover to cover — the ledger, because the ledger only contains your own mistakes and therefore shrinks.

Your last forty-eight hours

- **13 February:** one full paper, timed at two hours, at 10:15 am. Mark it against the official answer key, not your own judgement.
- **13 February evening:** your two letter templates, written out from memory. Your notice format. Your five composition openings from the week's practice.
- **14 February:** nothing new. Re-read the error ledger for grammar. Two compositions, planned but not written. Sleep by 10 pm.
- **15 February, 9:45 am:** seated. Fifteen-minute protocol. Time budget written on the booklet: 30 / 20 / 12 / 35 / 18 / 5.

LITERATURE IN ENGLISH — THURSDAY 18 FEBRUARY

Literature in English — Thursday 18 February

Two hours, 80 marks plus 20 internal, and you have two clear days after English Language before it. Those two days are the whole of your revision for this paper, so the preparation has to be done long before them.

What this paper rewards

Literature is marked on three things, in this order: that you answered the question asked, that you supported it with evidence from the text, and that your writing is controlled. Most students invert the order — they write everything they know about the text and hope the question is somewhere inside it.

The five highest-yield moves

1. **Build a quote bank now, not in February.** One page per text: twelve to fifteen short quotations you can deploy anywhere, with a note on what each one proves. Short quotes are worth more than long ones because you can embed them in a sentence.
2. **Practise the question, not the text.** Take one past question per text per week and write only the opening paragraph and the plan. Fifteen minutes, and it teaches you to read a question properly.
3. **Underline the command word.** “How does the writer create tension” is a question about technique. “What does this reveal about the character” is a question about character. The same quotation answers both, but the paragraph around it must be different.
4. **Learn three poems, two stories and two scenes really well** rather than everything shallowly — then extend. Depth is what earns the top band, and choice in the paper lets you use it.
5. **Write in the present tense about the text.** “The poet presents…”, not “the poet presented…”. Small, and it reads as control.

> **THE TWO-DAY WINDOW, PLANNED**
>
> 17 February: your quote banks and your three best-prepared texts, plus one timed essay. 18 February morning: your plans for six likely questions and nothing else. Do not read a new text on either day — there is no time to learn it and it will displace what you have.

MATHEMATICS — MONDAY 22 FEBRUARY

Mathematics — Monday 22 February

Three clear days after Literature, and the paper with the most predictable marks in your whole combination. Mathematics does not reward reading. It rewards the number of problems you have solved with a pen and checked against a solution.

Where the marks go

ICSE mathematics marking is step-based: marks are attached to the working, not to the final answer. A student who reaches a wrong answer with correct method routinely scores most of the marks; a student who writes only the correct answer routinely does not. This single fact should change how you write.

The three-pass method for the paper

Pass	What you do	Why
First	Answer every question you can do immediately, in any order. Skip nothing you are unsure of — mark it and move.	Banks the marks you already own before the clock pressures you.
Second	Return to the marked questions. Write the given, the formula, and the first step even if you cannot finish.	Step marks. A half-solved question scores; a blank one cannot.
Third	Check units, check that every sub-part is answered, check that the answer is plausible.	The cheapest marks on the paper, and the ones most often skipped.

The five highest-yield moves

1. **Solve, do not read solutions.** A solution read feels understood for about twenty minutes. A problem solved is yours. The ratio should be roughly one read solution to four attempted problems.

2. **Keep one page of formulae per chapter** and rebuild it from memory each Sunday. If you cannot rebuild it, you do not know it.
3. **Write the formula before substituting.** It is a mark, it prevents errors, and it earns partial credit when the arithmetic goes wrong.
4. **Do the geometry and construction work by hand, with instruments.** Constructions are marks you can bank completely, and they are usually the last thing students practise.
5. **Time one full paper a week from January.** Mathematics is the paper where the clock, not the knowledge, is the binding constraint.

> **THE SILENT MARK-LOSER**
>
> Working in the margin, then writing the answer without the steps. It looks tidy and it costs three or four marks a paper. Every step you took in the margin belongs in the answer.

HISTORY AND CIVICS — FRIDAY 26 FEBRUARY

History and Civics — Friday 26 February

Four days after Mathematics, and three clear days before Geography. This is the first place in the timetable where the dead-day trap opens up: it is very tempting to spend all three days here and arrive at Geography cold.

How to revise a content-heavy subject in three days

Not by reading the textbook again. By testing yourself against a structure you already built. If you did not build one in Phase 1, build it now and accept that it will be thinner than you would like.

1. **Day one — the skeleton.** For each chapter, write the headings only: causes, events, consequences, key people, key dates. One page per chapter. You are rebuilding the shape, not the detail.
2. **Day two — the evidence.** Under each heading, add three or four facts. Not paragraphs. Facts. Dates, names, acts, figures.
3. **Day three — the questions.** Answer past questions using only your skeleton. Where you cannot, that heading is your gap, and the gap list is what you revise on the morning of the paper.

The Civics half is different from the History half

History rewards chronology and cause. Civics rewards precision about institutions: what a body does, who it answers to, what its powers are. Students who revise them the same way score unevenly. For Civics, build a table — institution, function, composition, one example — and test yourself against the table, not the chapter.

> **DO NOT FORGET GEOGRAPHY IN THIS WINDOW**
>
> Take one of these three days and give 90 minutes to Geography. It is the difference between arriving at 1 March prepared and arriving at 1 March hoping.

GEOGRAPHY — MONDAY 1 MARCH

Geography — Monday 1 March

Three days after History and Civics, two clear days before Hindi. Geography is the subject in your combination most likely to be quietly neglected, because it sits in the middle of the run and does not feel urgent until it is three days away.

The three components that behave differently

Component	What it demands	How to practise it
Physical and regional geography	Cause and process, explained in sequence.	Explain a process aloud in five sentences, then write it. If you cannot say it, you cannot write it.
Map work	Accuracy, not knowledge. Names spelled correctly, symbols in the right place.	Twenty minutes, three times a week, with a blank outline map and a pen. There is no other way to learn this.
Topographical sheet interpretation	Reading a document you have never seen.	Do one full topo question a week from January. The skill is pattern recognition and it only comes from repetition.

The map is free marks

Map work is the most mechanical part of any ICSE paper and the most reliably scored. A student who spends twenty minutes three times a week from December on blank outline maps will bank nearly all of it. A student who “will do maps later” will lose most of it, because map marking cannot be crammed — the error is spatial, not verbal.

THE CHEAPEST 20 MINUTES IN YOUR WEEK

Print forty blank outline maps and keep them in your bag. Whenever you have twenty minutes and no plan, mark ten features from memory and check them. By March you will have done the equivalent of a month of map revision in gaps you would otherwise have spent on a phone.

HINDI AND YOUR SECOND LANGUAGE — THURSDAY 4 MARCH

Hindi and your second language — Thursday 4 March

Three days after Geography, four clear days before Physics. Language papers run longer than most — check the duration printed against your own language on the official timetable and practise at that length.

The marks are in the fixed sections

A language paper almost always has a section that is trainable and a section that is unpredictable. The trainable part — grammar, prescribed-text questions, format writing — is where the marks are concentrated and where a fortnight of focused work moves your score furthest. The composition is where students spend most of their time and where the spread between students is narrowest.

1. **Learn the formats cold.** Letter, notice, advertisement, email — whatever your syllabus prescribes. Format marks are unconditional if you have practised them and unavailable if you have not.
2. **Do grammar daily for ten minutes.** Not weekly for an hour. Language grammar is retention, and retention needs frequency.

3. **Prepare five composition topics you can write about well** — a person, a place, an event, an opinion, a problem — and be ready to adapt one of them to whatever prompt appears.
4. **Write by hand, in the script you will use.** Students who type their practice and then handwrite for three hours discover a stamina problem on the day.

PHYSICS — MONDAY 8 MARCH

Physics — Monday 8 March

Four days after Hindi, three clear days before Chemistry. The science papers arrive in a cluster, which is good news: the three of them share revision habits, and the three-day gaps are enough if you use the 3-3-3 block properly.

What the 2027 Chemistry specimen already tells you

The specimen papers carry skill tags in the margin, and in the Chemistry specimen the Application tag appears most often. Read that as a warning about the whole science cluster: the paper is less interested in whether you can state a law and more interested in whether you can use it.

The five highest-yield moves for Physics

1. **One formula sheet, rebuilt weekly.** Every formula with its symbols, units and the condition under which it applies. Units are marks.
2. **Numericals before theory.** A numerical forces you to use the concept. If you can solve the problems in a chapter, the theory questions in that chapter become easy.
3. **Diagrams, drawn and labelled, from memory.** Ray diagrams, circuit diagrams, force diagrams. Draw, label, then check. Not look, then copy.
4. **Write the unit in every single numerical answer.** It is the most frequently lost mark in the subject and it takes one second to keep.
5. **Answer definitions in one line, then add the example.** Under the 2027 pattern, a definition alone rarely fills a multi-mark question.

> **THE WINDOW YOU ACTUALLY HAVE**
>
> 5, 6 and 7 March are yours. Use 5 and 6 for Physics and give 7 March morning to Chemistry's first pass — Chemistry follows in four days and cannot be learned from scratch in three.

CHEMISTRY — FRIDAY 12 MARCH

Chemistry — Friday 12 March

Four days after Physics, three clear days before Biology. Chemistry is the subject in the science cluster where students most often know more than their marks suggest, because the paper demands precision of a specific kind: equations balanced, conditions stated, tests described exactly.

Precision is the whole subject

Where marks leak	What the examiner needs	The drill
Chemical equations	Balanced, with state symbols and conditions where the syllabus requires them.	Write twenty equations a week from memory. Balance, then check.
Tests and observations	The reagent, the observation, and the inference — all three.	Build a three-column table per group. Test yourself against the observation column only.
Definitions and laws	The exact terms the syllabus uses.	Write them, do not read them. A definition you have only read will come back wrong.
Numericals	The formula, the substitution, the unit.	Same method as Physics: formula first, then numbers, then unit.

THE SINGLE BEST REVISION ARTEFACT IN CHEMISTRY

One sheet, three columns: reagent, observation, inference. Every qualitative test in your syllabus on one page. Students who build this sheet in December score disproportionately well on the practical-based questions, because those questions are asking you to read that sheet backwards.

BIOLOGY — MONDAY 15 MARCH

Biology — Monday 15 March

Three days after Chemistry, two clear days before Computer Applications. Biology is the most diagram-dependent paper in your combination and therefore the one where a specific, mechanical skill pays fastest.

Draw, label, then check

A labelled diagram in Biology earns marks for shape, for labels, and for the labels being on the right structures. Students lose marks for arrows that point at nothing, for labels written inside the drawing, and for a diagram copied from the book without ever having drawn it themselves.

The drill: take a blank sheet, draw the diagram from memory, label it, then open the book and mark your errors in red. Twenty diagrams in a fortnight, done this way, is worth more than two hours of looking at them.

The five highest-yield moves

1. **One diagram list per unit**, and every item on it drawn from memory at least twice before March.
2. **Definitions in the syllabus's own words** — one line each, tested by writing, not reading.
3. **Processes as sequences.** Photosynthesis, respiration, digestion, circulation: learn them as ordered steps, because that is how the marks are given.
4. **Genetics problems, solved on paper.** Punnett squares and pedigree questions are pure method, and method is learnable in a week.
5. **Do not skip the application questions.** With roughly half the paper testing application in 2027, a Biology paper will ask you about situations your textbook never described.

COMPUTER APPLICATIONS AND GROUP III — WEDNESDAY 17 MARCH

Computer Applications and Group III — Wednesday 17 March

Two days after Biology, one clear day before your Group I language. Group III subjects are marked 50 for the board paper and 50 for internal assessment — which changes the arithmetic completely.

HALF OF THIS PAPER IS ALREADY WRITTEN

In a Group III subject your school's internal assessment is worth as much as the board paper. That means the board paper is not out of 100 in your head; it is out of 50, and it is the half you can still influence. Check your internal marks this week, and if something is unsubmitted or unclear, ask your teacher now rather than in March.

The one-day gap

You have 16 March, and nothing else. Do not attempt a full revision of the subject. Do this instead, in this order: your error ledger first, then the two topics you are least confident about, then one timed section. That is a day well spent. Trying to cover the whole syllabus in one day produces anxiety, not marks.

For Computer Applications specifically

- Write code by hand, on paper, without an editor. The board paper is handwritten and syntax errors cost marks you would not make on a computer.
- Know the difference between what the syllabus requires and what your school taught. The syllabus document on cisce.org is the authority.
- Practise writing output questions by tracing the code on paper, line by line, rather than guessing the answer.
- If your practical file or project is still incomplete, that is the highest-priority task in this entire book for you, and it is worth more than any revision you will do in March.

THE LONG TAIL — 19 TO 31 MARCH

The long tail — 19 to 31 March

If your combination includes a Group I language on 19 March, Environmental Science on 25 March, Commercial Studies on 29 March or Economics, French or Sanskrit on 31 March, you have the most dangerous stretch of the year: papers spaced four to six days apart, after you have already sat seven or eight, when your motivation is at its lowest.

Two things are true about this stretch. The marks count exactly as much as the marks from February. And almost every student in the country will spend it half-resting, which means the return on a disciplined two weeks here is unusually high.

How to run it

Days before the paper	What to do
6 to 4 days out	Full pass over the subject, using your Phase 1 summary. One timed section per day. This is where the marks are made.
3 to 2 days out	Past questions only. Nothing new. Ledger entries for everything you still get wrong.
1 day out	Your own notes, your formula or definition sheet, and an early night. No full paper.

Days before the paper	What to do
Between papers	Keep the maintenance block going for the paper after next. Do not treat a four-day gap as a holiday.

IF 31 MARCH IS YOUR LAST PAPER

That is 45 days after your first. Pace yourself accordingly: the students who burn out are almost always the ones who treated February as a sprint. Sleep is not a reward for finishing revision; it is part of the revision.

05

Tools, trackers and the last mile

Answer writing, the error ledger, mocks, internal marks, memory, parents, and the checklists you print.

ANSWER WRITING THAT EARNS MARKS

Answer writing that earns marks

Two students with identical knowledge can differ by fifteen marks a paper on presentation alone. ICSE marking is point-based: an examiner is looking for specific ideas and ticking them. Make the ticking easy.

1. **Number every answer exactly as the question is numbered.** Not “Q2” when the question is “2(a)(iii)”. An examiner who cannot find your answer cannot mark it.
2. **Leave a line between answers and start each on a new line.** Crowded booklets lose marks to nothing but layout.
3. **Answer in points where the question has multiple parts.** Three reasons should look like three reasons, not like a paragraph containing three reasons.
4. **Put the final answer in a box or underline it** in numerical subjects, with the unit.
5. **Label every diagram**, in pencil, with a ruler for straight lines, and never inside the drawing.
6. **Respect word limits.** A fifty-word summary is not seventy words. Examiners do not reward the extra twenty; the rubric penalises them.
7. **Never leave a question blank.** A definition, a formula, a labelled diagram, a reasoned guess — something. Zero is the only score you are guaranteed.

THE MARGIN RULE

Use the left margin of the booklet for nothing except question numbers. Use the right margin for nothing at all. Work in the body of the page, in order, with visible steps. Tidiness is not vanity in a point-based marking system; it is the difference between an examiner finding your third mark and not.

THE ERROR LEDGER

The error ledger

One notebook. One page per subject. Every mark you lose, recorded with its cause. This is the highest-return artefact in the entire plan, and almost nobody keeps one properly.

The format

Column	What goes in it
Date	The day you got it wrong.
Question	The question, in five words. Enough to recognise it.
What I wrote	Your actual answer, briefly. Not what you wish you had written.
What was right	The correct answer or the missing step.
Why	One of four: did not know / knew but forgot / misread / ran out of time.
Fix	One line. The rule, the formula, the format, or the habit.

Why the fourth column is the whole point

Because the four causes need four different responses, and students apply the same response — more reading — to all of them.

Cause	The only fix that works
Did not know	Learn it. This is the one cause that needs new content.
Knew but forgot	Spaced revision. Put it on the 1-3-7 schedule.
Misread the question	Command-word drill: ten questions a day, just identifying what is being asked.
Ran out of time	Time budgeting in the reading window, and practising at real speed.

Review the ledger every Sunday. Anything that appears three times is not a mistake any more — it is a habit, and habits need a different intervention: a written rule on the first page of the subject's notebook, read before every paper.

START IT TODAY, EVEN IF IT IS EMPTY

An empty ledger opened on 14 November becomes a full one by January. A perfect ledger planned for 1 January never exists.

MOCK PAPERS: HOW MANY, AND HOW TO MARK THEM

Mock papers: how many, and how to mark them

A mock paper is not a test of whether you will pass. It is a diagnostic that tells you where your next ten hours should go. Used properly, eight to twelve papers between January and February will do more for your score than any other single activity.

Which papers to use, in this order

1. **The 2027 CISCE specimen paper, with its official answer key**, for every subject where one exists. These are the only papers written for your exam year.
2. **Recent board papers**, marked against their published marking schemes. Not the ones with a coaching centre's answers — the official scheme, because that is what the examiner will use.
3. **Older papers, for topic practice only.** The pattern has moved; the content has not.

The rules of a mock

- Real duration. Real time of day — 10:15 am from January onwards.
- No notes, no phone, no pauses. A paper done in three sittings is three exercises, not a mock.
- Mark it the same evening, against the official key, and be harsh.
- Fill in the ledger before you go to bed. A mock you did not analyse was a waste of two hours.
- Record the score in the tracker in this section. The trend matters; the number does not.

DO NOT DO A FULL PAPER THE DAY BEFORE AN EXAM

The last twenty-four hours are for consolidation, not performance. A poor mock on the eve of a paper damages confidence and teaches you nothing you can act on in time.

THE INTERNAL MARKS YOU CAN STILL PROTECT

The internal marks you can still protect

Between a fifth and a half of your marks in each subject are awarded by your school and submitted online to CISCE. They are not negotiable in February, but they are not all closed in November either. This week, find out three things:

1. **What has already been submitted** and what is still pending, subject by subject.
2. **Whether any project, file, journal or practical record is incomplete** — and if so, the deadline.
3. **Whether your Socially Useful Productive Work and Community Service grade is recorded.** A pass grade there is a condition of the certificate, not a formality.

Then act on the answer this month. A completed Computer Applications file is worth more than three weekends of revision in March, and it takes one weekend in November.

> **THE QUESTION TO ASK YOUR TEACHER**
>
> Not “am I doing well?”. Ask: “Is anything of mine pending or incomplete for internal assessment, and what is the last date?” That question has a specific answer and it is the only one that changes what you do next.

The SUPW and Community Service grade

It is assessed internally and shown on your result sheet as A to E, with A to D a pass and E a failure. It does not add to your percentage, but a failure grade blocks the certificate. Confirm with your school that your record is complete.

MEMORY: THE 1-3-7 RULE

Memory: the 1-3-7 rule

You will forget most of what you learn this week. That is not a personal failing; it is how memory works, and the fix is scheduling rather than effort. The 1-3-7 rule is the cheapest version of that schedule.

When	What you do	How long
Day 1	Learn the chapter. Then, the same evening, close the book and write what you remember.	8 minutes
Day 3	Blank-page test on the same chapter. Mark the gaps in red.	10 minutes
Day 7	Blank-page test again, plus the red list from day 3.	10 minutes
Day 21	One more test, folded into your weekly revision block.	10 minutes

Three short tests, twenty-eight minutes in total, will do more for retention than an hour of re-reading spread across the same three weeks. The mechanism is retrieval: every time you pull something out of memory, the path to it gets stronger. Reading does not do that.

The blank-page test, precisely

1. Name the topic out loud.

2 Close every book.

3 Write everything you know on one sheet for eight minutes. Diagrams included.

4 Open the book. Mark what you missed in red.

5 The red list is your next revision. Nothing else.

WHY THIS FEELS WORSE AND WORKS BETTER

Retrieval practice feels harder than re-reading and produces lower confidence. That is exactly why students avoid it, and exactly why it works. If your revision feels comfortable, it is probably not doing much.

SLEEP, SCREENS AND THE FOUR-HOUR TRUTH

Sleep, screens and the four-hour truth

Three short points, because this section is usually written as a lecture and lectures are not read.

Sleep is a study tool

What you learn in the evening consolidates during sleep. Cutting sleep to add an hour of revision trades a strong hour for a weak one, and then charges you again the next morning at 10:15. Seven to eight hours, consistently, from now until 31 March. If you must choose between one more chapter and one more hour of sleep in February, choose sleep.

The phone is not the problem; the check is

A phone in another room for a 90-minute block is worth more than an app that tracks your usage. The damage is not the time spent; it is the interruption, which costs several minutes of re-focus each time. Put it in a drawer, in another room, during Block A. Not on silent, not face down. Another room.

Four hours of real study

Almost nobody does six hours of genuine cognitive work in a day. What looks like six hours is usually four hours of work and two hours of shuffling paper. Cap the real work at about four hours on school days and six on holidays, and protect the sleep and the breaks instead. A rested student who studies four hours beats an exhausted one who studies seven, every time, and the gap widens over five months.

THE ONE METRIC WORTH TRACKING

Not hours. Not pages. The number of questions you answered from memory and got right. That number goes up or it does not, and it is the only one that predicts your marks.

A PAGE FOR PARENTS

A page for parents

If you are the parent reading this, three things you do in the next four months will matter more than anything you can buy, and two common things will actively hurt.

What helps

1. **Protect the sleep and the food.** Not the study hours. A student who sleeps seven hours and eats properly will out-perform a student who does neither, whatever the timetable on the wall says.
2. **Ask about the plan, not the marks.** “What are you doing this week?” opens a conversation. “What did you get?” closes one, and after February it closes it permanently.
3. **Handle the logistics.** The centre is 2,835 centres across India and overseas; the reporting time is now earlier and candidates must be seated by 9:45 am. Know the route, leave earlier than feels necessary, and check the admit card for the centre's own instructions.

What hurts

1. **A new tuition in January or February.** A new teacher means a new method, new notes and a new vocabulary, six weeks before the paper. It almost always lowers the score.
2. **Comparison with a cousin, a neighbour or an older sibling.** The 2027 paper is a different paper from the one they sat, with roughly half its marks now testing application rather than recall. Their experience is genuinely less transferable than it feels.

The one thing to say after a bad paper

“That one is finished. What is the next one?” Then leave the room. In a ten-paper season, the ability to close a paper and move on is worth more than any single subject, and it is almost entirely a function of what happens in the car on the way home.

THE EXAM-DAY CHECKLIST

The exam-day checklist

The night before

- [ ] Admit card in the bag, in a plastic sleeve.
- [ ] Two blue or black pens, a pencil, eraser, sharpener, ruler, in a transparent pouch.
- [ ] A wristwatch. Not a smart watch.
- [ ] Centre address confirmed, and the route and travel time checked.
- [ ] Alarm set for 6:00 am, and a second alarm.
- [ ] Bag packed and left by the door before you sleep.
- [ ] Sleep by 10 pm. Not 11.

The morning

- [ ] Eat something. A paper written hungry is a paper written badly.
- [ ] Thirty minutes maximum of revision: formulae, diagram labels, key definitions. Nothing new.
- [ ] Leave early enough to be at the centre by 9:00 am.
- [ ] Seated by 9:45 am.
- [ ] No discussion of the syllabus with anyone outside the hall.

In the hall

- [ ] Fill in the roll number and details first, and check them twice.
- [ ] 10:00 to 10:15 — the fifteen-minute protocol: count pages, read instructions, read all questions, mark the paper, write your time budget.
- [ ] 10:15 — begin. Hardest confident question first is fine; the time budget is what matters.
- [ ] Last ten minutes — check that every question has an answer, every unit is written, every diagram is labelled.
- [ ] Hand over the booklet only when you have checked the page count and the roll number.

Afterwards

- [ ] Three lines in the error ledger. Twenty minutes, maximum.
- [ ] Do not compare answers. Not in the corridor, not on the bus, not in a group chat.
- [ ] Block A for the next paper, the same evening.
- [ ] Sleep at your normal time.

THE EXAM WINDOW ON ONE PAGE

The exam window on one page

Print this. Put it where you will see it every morning from February. The bold entries are exam days; the grey numbers are the days that decide the result.

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
15 English Language	**16 Art P4**	17	**18 Literature**	19	20	21
22 Mathematics	**23 Art P1**	**24 Group III B**	25	**26 History and Civics**	27	28
1 Geography	**2 Art P2**	3	**4 Hindi**	5	6	7
8 Physics	9	10	11	**12 Chemistry**	13	14
15 Biology	**16 Art P3**	**17 Group III A**	18	**19 Group I Languages**	20	21
22	23	24	**25 Env. Science**	26	27	28
29 Commercial Studies	30	**31 Economics**				

ICSE 2027 examination window, 15 February to 31 March. Art papers begin at 09:00 am; all other papers begin at 10:15 am, with candidates seated by 9:45 am.

THE TWENTY-ONE FREE DAYS

The twenty-one free days

Every day between two papers, for a typical ten-subject combination. Fill this in during January, not in the corridor. The rule from Part 2 applies to every row: about 60% of the day on the next paper, about 25% on the paper after it, and a short maintenance block on something further out.

Day	Date	Next paper	The paper after it	Your plan for the day
Tue	16 Feb	Literature in English (18 Feb)	Mathematics (22 Feb)	
Wed	17 Feb	Literature in English (18 Feb)	Mathematics (22 Feb)	
Fri	19 Feb	Mathematics (22 Feb)	History and Civics (26 Feb)	
Sat	20 Feb	Mathematics (22 Feb)	History and Civics (26 Feb)	
Sun	21 Feb	Mathematics (22 Feb)	History and Civics (26 Feb)	
Tue	23 Feb	History and Civics (26 Feb)	Geography (1 Mar)	
Wed	24 Feb	History and Civics (26 Feb)	Geography (1 Mar)	
Thu	25 Feb	History and Civics (26 Feb)	Geography (1 Mar)	
Sat	27 Feb	Geography (1 Mar)	Hindi (4 Mar)	
Sun	28 Feb	Geography (1 Mar)	Hindi (4 Mar)	
Tue	2 Mar	Hindi (4 Mar)	Physics (8 Mar)	
Wed	3 Mar	Hindi (4 Mar)	Physics (8 Mar)	
Fri	5 Mar	Physics (8 Mar)	Chemistry (12 Mar)	
Sat	6 Mar	Physics (8 Mar)	Chemistry (12 Mar)	
Sun	7 Mar	Physics (8 Mar)	Chemistry (12 Mar)	
Tue	9 Mar	Chemistry (12 Mar)	Biology (15 Mar)	
Wed	10 Mar	Chemistry (12 Mar)	Biology (15 Mar)	
Thu	11 Mar	Chemistry (12 Mar)	Biology (15 Mar)	
Sat	13 Mar	Biology (15 Mar)	Computer Applications (17 Mar)	
Sun	14 Mar	Biology (15 Mar)	Computer Applications (17 Mar)	
Tue	16 Mar	Computer Applications (17 Mar)	Last paper	

HOW TO FILL THIS IN PROPERLY

Do it in one sitting, in January, with your own subject combination in front of you. Write the subject and the specific topic for each block — not “revise Chemistry” but “Chapter 6 numericals, then the equations sheet”. A free day with a vague plan is a free day spent deciding what to do.

The trackers

Print these four pages. A plan on a screen is a plan you will not look at in December.

Tracker 1: syllabus coverage

One row per subject. Update it every Sunday. The only column that matters in December is the last one.

Subject	Chapters	Done	Partly	Not started	Closed by
English Language					
Literature in English					
Mathematics					
History and Civics					
Geography					
Second language					
Physics					
Chemistry					
Biology					
Group III subject					

Tracker 2: the 1-3-7 log

Chapter	Day 1	Day 3	Day 7	Day 21

THE TRACKERS, CONTINUED

The trackers, continued

Tracker 3: mock scores

Record the score and, more importantly, the cause. A flat score with changing causes is progress; a rising score with the same cause is luck.

Date	Subject	Score	Did not know	Forgot	Misread	Time

Tracker 4: the exam window

Fill this in as you go. It keeps the next paper in front of you and the last one out of your head.

Paper	Date	Block A done	Block B done	Maintenance	Written

IF A PAPER GOES BADLY

If a paper goes badly

It will happen to at least one paper, and probably to a paper you care about. What you do in the two hours afterwards matters more than the paper did.

1. **Close it in twenty minutes.** Three lines in the ledger: what went wrong, which cause, what you will do differently. Then shut the book. You cannot change a written paper and thinking about it is not revision.
2. **Do not check answers.** Not with friends, not with a textbook, not online. The only outcome is a worse mood before the next paper.
3. **Go to Block A that evening.** Not tomorrow. The next paper is the only thing you can still influence, and starting it tonight is what breaks the spiral.
4. **Remember the arithmetic.** Ten papers, most of them at 80 marks plus 20 internal. One weak paper is a small fraction of a certificate, and it is almost never the paper students believe it was.
5. **Tell one person and then stop telling people.** A parent, a teacher, a friend. Rehearsing the disappointment to five people turns one bad paper into a bad week.

THE SEASON IS DECIDED IN THE GAPS, NOT THE PAPERS

Nobody wins the ICSE in the exam hall. Students lose it in the corridor afterwards, or in the three days between papers when they do nothing. You have twenty-one of those days. They are the whole game.

WHERE TO CHECK EVERYTHING

Where to check everything

Every fact in this book comes from one of the following. If any of them changes, the document wins and this book is out of date on that point — so check the three that matter most to you before you rely on them.

The five documents

1. **The ICSE Year 2027 examination timetable**, published 10 November 2026 and available on cisce.org under Notifications. This is the authority on dates, start times and paper durations. Nothing else is.
2. **The ICSE Year 2027 Regulations**, on cisce.org. This is the authority on subject groups, the 80/20 and 50/50 splits, pass rules, grades and the six-subject requirement.
3. **The Regulations and Syllabuses for 2027**, subject by subject. This is the authority on what is in the syllabus and, where applicable, the topic-wise weightage — which CISCE has stated will be maintained without exception.
4. **The 2027 specimen question papers and answer keys**, published October 2026 for eleven ICSE Class 10 subjects. These fix the format, the section distribution, the choices offered and the skills assessed.
5. **The CISCE circular of 9 October 2026**, which sets competency-based questions at approximately 50% for the 2027 examinations.

Three cautions

- CISCE has said plainly that the board papers may not replicate the specimen papers, because individual questions vary. Use the specimen for format, the syllabus for content.
- Coaching-centre answer keys are not marking schemes. Where CISCE publishes a key, use it.
- Any revision notice issued after 14 November 2026 is not reflected in this book. Check cisce.org before you plan around a date.

ICSE 2027: The 90-Day Board Plan · Digitalaikart · digitalkartai.shop · Edition of 14 November 2026. Prepared independently; not affiliated with or endorsed by CISCE. Always verify dates and rules against cisce.org.